denouncing the Soviet Union.'[43] Arthur Schlesinger was an early and persistent critic of the operation and warned the action would be seen as 'calculated aggression against a small nation in defiance both of treaty obligations and of the international standards we have repeatedly asserted against the Communist world.'[44]

The Cuban Expeditionary Force (CEF) – as it was known in Washington – had been trained by the CIA and equipped with US-supplied weapons, including aircraft and tanks. Its transports and amphibious assault ships were provided by the agency and escorted to Cuba by the United States Navy. However, the President insisted that no US forces were to be involved in the conflict. On 12 April he told a White House press conference: 'there will not be, under any conditions, an intervention in Cuba by the United States Armed Forces. This Government will do everything it possibly can … to make sure that are no Americans involved in any actions inside Cuba.'[45] Privately, he told his aides, 'The minute I land one marine, we're in this thing up to our necks. I can't get the United States into a war and then lose it, no matter what it takes. I'm not going to risk an American Hungary. And that's what it could be, a fucking slaughter. Is that understood, gentlemen?'[46] In fact, unbeknownst to the President and his senior officials, the landing parties ahead of the attack near the small village of Playa Giron were led by CIA officers, and some of the pilots who flew the Brigade's Douglas Invader B-26 bombers were members of the Alabama Air National Guard (several of whom died in the operation).

Kennedy appears to have made up his mind to proceed with Operation Zapata during his Easter weekend break at Palm Springs in California. His deliberations may have been aided by his father, who some suspected of being a decisive voice in the President's ear. JFK returned to Washington on 4 April, and with his advisers listened to a detailed briefing from Richard Bissell. Senator Fulbright was also invited and provided objection in principle: 'If one has faith in the human values of the United States, and if that faith is supported by vigorous and intelligent action, then there is no need to fear competition from an unshaven megalomaniac.'[47] None of the President's senior advisers – Rusk, McNamara, Bundy, or Lemnitzer –